

the guise of giving it to the man and sticking it to big brother while calling it an expression of freedom. Your character does not seem to have any problem with any of that, and will blatantly continue to break the law just to get vengeance and get back a car. Now that would be fine if the character you are playing had a history with crime and being an overall douche, but if that is the case, it is never truly explored in the story. So from a storytelling perspective, it does not make sense for our character to be doing what he/she is doing, all to get a bit of revenge.

Gameplay

Need for Speed Unbound follows the tried and tested template of most racing games that are not track-focused. It's the usual open-world racing game experience with a few things here and there that make it a quintessential Need for Speed game. We already spoke about the cop-chasing dynamic of the game and that can be a bit of a problem while exploring the open world in case you have a couple of bars of heat on you. Apart from that, the world seems pretty generic with the map having a city area with lots of interconnecting roads and people along with a whole lot of open spaces outside the city area with a decent number of mountain roads and countrysides to explore.

In terms of car handling and control, it seems a bit off. It's also difficult to explain what exactly is off about it. The easiest way we can think of to explain it is that every car you decide to drive has a horrible case of understeer to it. Meaning, turning the car seems more difficult than it needs to be. The car feels super heavy and does not want to turn as sharply as you want it to and

just keeps going forward. For handling, cars can be tuned for either grip or drift but even in the drift tune, the cars don't seem to let go of their understeer-y nature which is absolutely weird because technically drifting is a byproduct of oversteer and not understeer. Let's just say that the handling dynamics in Need For Speed Unbound are not consistent and a lot of the time you don't

crashing an opponent early in the race, leaving them far behind only for them catch back up with you by the middle of the race. To add salt to the wound, they might even overtake you while you are deploying nitrous and they are not! Oof.

Verdict

Unbound takes the arcade racing genre of games and repackages it with a cool look. Don't get us wrong, the visuals are definitely something that differentiates Unbound from similar games. They give Unbound a unique identity making it instantly recognizable among the scores of racing games out there.

The issue is that Need for Speed has not taken the same approach with the rest of the game. It's more of 'same old same old' with the rest of the game as far as we can see. It is set in an open world, just like older Need for Speed games and other racing games, the visuals of the environment and cars are again nothing we have not seen before, the story is forgettable and unreliable, early game grinding is quite tedious and the handling is all over the place. As nice as the visuals are, it is not enough to save Unbound from the chasm of generic-ness.

A more thought-out storyline, with less annoying (read: cringe-inducing) character interactions, would have been one of the places Criterion could have really improved the playability of the game and made the grind worth it. But alas, the sheer potential of the game has gone down the drain. It sort of feels like the developers simply added the fancy new visuals to hide pretty much everything recycled from every other racing game out there, and not too well might we add. *



know how the vehicle will react to your input. For an arcade racing game, that is not great as players expect consistency (even if unrealistic) to perform the combos and tricks mid-race.

Like we mentioned earlier, the AI can be quite vicious. To the point where even those who enjoy a challenge might get frustrated. Imagine